

*Tyto alba*

## Western barn owl



**Location** North, Central, and South America, Europe, Asia, Africa, Australia

**Length** 11½–17½ in (29–44 cm)

**Weight** 11–23 oz (300–650 g)

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Nonmigrant

**Status** Least concern



Found on all continents except Antarctica, the western barn owl is the most widespread of all species of owls, and one of the most widely distributed of all land birds. It has a pale, heart-shaped face, long legs covered in white feathers, and a very short tail. The female lays eggs in a hollow tree or an abandoned building. She feeds the young with food brought by the male; she also broods them for up to 3 weeks from hatching, until they have acquired the down they need to keep themselves warm. Changing agricultural practices have reduced the barn owl's food supply; in some areas, this species is now rare.



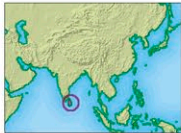
### ON TARGET

The western barn owl is an expert hunter, its excellent vision and hearing enabling it to pinpoint prey in total darkness. It flies low, slowly and silently, then swoops swiftly to the ground. At the last moment, it swings its legs forward, spreading its sharp-clawed toes to grasp and kill its prey.



*Otus thilohoffmanni*

## Serendib scops owl



**Location** Sri Lanka

**Length** 6½ in (17 cm)

**Weight** Not known

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Nonmigrant

**Status** Endangered



First detected in 1995 by its unfamiliar frog-like call in the rainforests of Sri Lanka, this owl was not seen until 2001—when it was photographed and its identity as a new species was confirmed. It is a very small, short-tailed, brownish red owl and has an indistinct facial disk; its eyes are orange in the male, yellow in the female. This species is known only from the lowland wet forests of southwestern Sri Lanka, favoring disturbed areas with tall, dense secondary vegetation and roosting close to the ground. There are probably around 250–1,000 individuals, but the secretive habits of this owl make population estimates difficult. However, this small population is likely to be in decline due to the habitat degradation.

*Otus scops*

## Eurasian scops owl



**Location** Europe to C. Asia, Africa

**Length** 6½–8 in (16–20 cm)

**Weight** 2½–4 oz (60–125 g)

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Migrant

**Status** Least concern



Small and superbly camouflaged, this owl is heard more often than it is seen, its call being a low whistle, repeated every few seconds. The fine, black flecks in its gray or reddish brown plumage make it almost invisible against the bark of a tree. When alarmed, it will stretch itself, and even sway, to imitate a branch and remain hidden. This owl feeds mainly on insects, swooping down on them from a perch, but also eats spiders, earthworms, reptiles, bats, and small birds.



*Otus lempiji*

## Sunda scops owl



**Location** S.E. Asia

**Length** 8 in (20 cm)

**Weight** 3½–4 oz (100–125 g)

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Nonmigrant

**Status** Least concern



The Sunda scops owl is a small, eared owl, with brown eyes. It occurs in both a brownish gray and a reddish morph. Inhabiting forests, forest edges, plantations, and areas with scattered

trees, such as parks and villages, it spends much of the day sitting camouflaged in hiding places, coming out at dusk to hunt mainly for insects. Males and females often call together, giving out a short, mellow hooting call.



*Scotopelia peli*

## Pel's fishing owl



**Location** Africa

**Length** 22–25 in (55–63 cm)

**Weight** 4½–5½ lb (2–2.5 kg)

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Nonmigrant

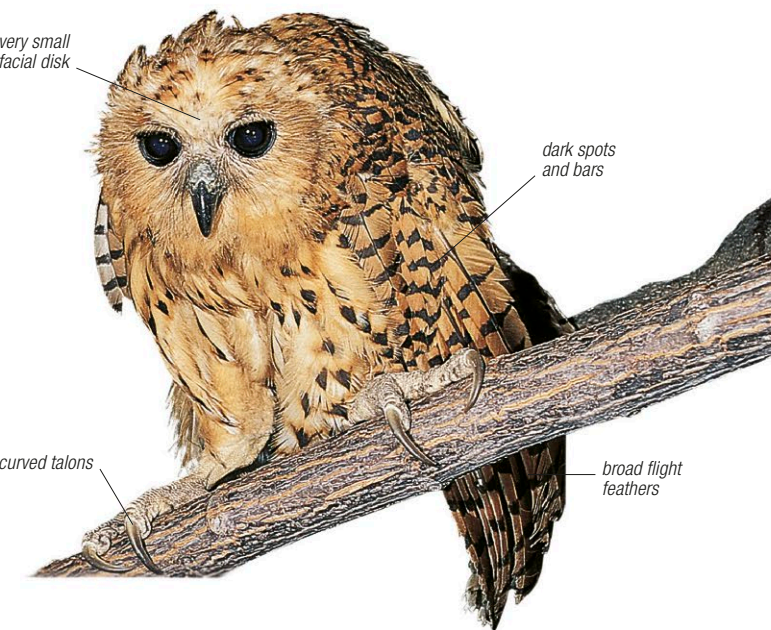
**Status** Least concern



This owl is one of 3 African species that specialize in feeding on fish, frogs, and other freshwater animals. Like its relatives, Pel's fishing owl has long, bare legs and curved talons that help

it grasp its slippery prey. The plumage of Pel's fishing owl is generally light chestnut, with dark spots and bars, which help camouflage it while it roosts. This large owl lives on the wooded edges of lakes, rivers, swamps, and marshes. It hunts after dark, launching itself from a perch and swooping low over the water. Having seized its prey, it returns to a perch to feed. It makes its nest in a tree hole, usually near water. Females lay one or 2 eggs, but normally only one young owl is reared. Both parents feed and rear the young, which may remain in the nest area for up to 8 months after fledging. A separate group of fishing owls—belonging to the genus *Keputa*—is found in Asia.

very small facial disk



*Pulsatrix perspicillata*

## Spectacled owl



**Location** S. Mexico to C. South America

**Length** 17–20½ in (43–52 cm)

**Weight** 21–36 oz (600–1,000 g)

**Plumage** Sexes alike

**Migration** Nonmigrant

**Status** Least concern



This owl, common in the American tropics, gets its name from the ring of white feathers, or "spectacles," around its eyes. Most often found in dense rain forest, it also lives in woodland edges and coffee plantations. Instead

of patrolling on the wing like many owls, it hunts from a perch, snatching prey from the ground or foliage. It usually preys on small forest mammals and insects, but also hunts near water, taking crawfish and crabs.

"spectacles" of white feathers

dark brown band across upper breast

